

Brief

Wisconsin Salary Baseline for Junior Developers and the Case for AI-Augmented AAISE Pathways

This brief uses **Wisconsin** as the base market for estimating starting salaries for a **junior developer who has just graduated with an associate degree in software engineering or a closely related IT/software development program**. Because labor-market sources rarely isolate salary by exact associate-degree title, the estimates below use current Wisconsin data for **junior software developer, software developer, software engineer, and web developer** roles as the best available proxy.

The purpose is twofold:

- Establish a reasonable **Wisconsin starting salary baseline**
- Show why keeping the **Associate of AI Software Engineering (AAISE) / IT curriculum current with AI-augmented engineering skills** strengthens the value proposition for students and supports response to current AI program velocity concerns

Wisconsin Baseline

A practical Wisconsin estimate for a newly graduated junior developer is:

- **Typical starting range:** \$65,000-\$75,000/year
- **Practical midpoint:** \$69,000-\$72,000/year
- **Conservative floor:** \$60,000-\$65,000/year
- **Strong first offer:** \$75,000-\$85,000+

This estimate is grounded in current statewide market data:

- Wisconsin **Software Developers** show **\$63,120 at the 10th percentile, \$82,280 at the 25th percentile, and \$103,360 median** in 2024 BLS wage data via O*NET: [O*NET Wisconsin Software Developers wages](#)
- Wisconsin **Junior Software Developer** postings on ZipRecruiter show **\$67,600 at the 25th percentile and \$89,808 average** as of **April 26, 2026**: [ZipRecruiter Junior Software Developer Wisconsin](#)
- Wisconsin **Web Developer** salary on Indeed averages **\$61,729** as of **April 13, 2026**: [Indeed Web Developer Wisconsin](#)
- Wisconsin **Software Engineer** salary on Indeed averages **\$109,696** as of **April 18, 2026**: [Indeed Software Engineer Wisconsin](#)

Breakdown 1: By City

Estimated starting pay for a junior developer in Wisconsin varies by regional labor market:

Area	Estimated entry-level annual	Hourly equivalent
Madison	\$72,000-\$82,000	\$34.62-\$39.42
Milwaukee metro	\$68,000-\$78,000	\$32.69-\$37.50
Green Bay / Appleton / Fox Valley	\$64,000-\$74,000	\$30.77-\$35.58
Rural / southwest / non-metro Wisconsin	\$60,000-\$70,000	\$28.85-\$33.65

These are consistent with metro-level wage differences shown in Wisconsin occupational wage data: [O*NET Wisconsin Software Developers wages](#)

Breakdown 2: By Role

Starting salary also depends on job title and technical expectations:

Role	Estimated annual	Hourly equivalent
Junior Software Developer	\$67,000-\$75,000	\$32.21-\$36.06
Web Developer	\$60,000-\$68,000	\$28.85-\$32.69
Software Developer / Engineer I	\$72,000-\$85,000	\$34.62-\$40.87
QA / Test Automation entry-level	\$58,000-\$68,000	\$27.88-\$32.69

This helps clarify that a student’s first wage outcome may differ depending on whether they enter web development, software engineering, or testing/automation work.

Breakdown 3: By Experience Ramp

For students and program stakeholders, the most useful view may be the early-career wage ramp:

Experience level	Estimated annual	Hourly equivalent
0 years, just graduated	\$65,000-\$75,000	\$31.25-\$36.06
1 year experience	\$72,000-\$82,000	\$34.62-\$39.42
2 years experience	\$78,000-\$92,000	\$37.50-\$44.23

This suggests that even modest early experience can move graduates well beyond entry-level wages within the first one to two years.

WTCS / SWTC Audience Context

For a **WTCS or SWTC audience**, market wages alone are not the only relevant lens. Program value is often discussed in relation to whether completers enter **high-wage** employment.

Two reference points matter here:

- **SWTC** classifies **high-wage programs** as those leading to jobs paying **\$25.00/hour and higher** in its district framework: [SWTC Board Packet, March 28, 2024](#)
- **WTCS** policy and Perkins guidance define high-wage outcomes relative to the institution’s or district’s median graduate entry wage, rather than a single statewide number: [WTCS Policy Manual](#), [WTCS Perkins FY 2026-27 Guidelines](#)

Using the SWTC threshold as a plain-language benchmark:

- **\$25/hour is about \$52,000/year**
- The estimated junior developer starting ranges in Wisconsin are generally **above that threshold**
- Even conservative entry-level estimates usually exceed the threshold by a meaningful margin

That makes software development and related **Associate of AI Software Engineering (AAISE)** aligned pathways strong candidates for a **high-wage** classification in practical student-facing terms.

AI-Augmented Engineers Caveat

A useful caveat is that the market is changing, and increasingly the target is not simply “developer,” but **AI-augmented developer or engineer**.

The evidence supports making this point carefully:

- PwC reports that **US workers with advanced AI skills earned a 56% wage premium** in its 2025 analysis: [PwC US AI Jobs Barometer](#)
- PwC’s earlier USA report found that job postings demanding AI skills were associated with a **25% wage premium**, and listed **applications programmers at 32%**: [PwC USA PDF](#)
- A 2026 hiring experiment found that AI skills increased interview invitation probabilities by about **8 to 15 percentage points**, including for software engineering roles: [AI Skills Improve Job Prospects](#)

- Research on AI-enhanced developers argues that future-ready programs should teach both AI tool use and core engineering judgment to avoid deskilling and improve adaptability: [AI-Enhanced Software Developer Research](#)

This does **not** prove that every junior graduate with AI exposure will automatically earn a higher salary. Wisconsin-specific salary tables for “AI-augmented associate-degree junior developers” do not yet exist in a clean form. However, the national evidence strongly suggests that AI capability is becoming a valuable hiring and wage signal.

For the **Associate of AI Software Engineering (AAISE) degree**, that strengthens the argument that curriculum modernization is not optional. It is part of maintaining program relevance, employability, and wage competitiveness.

Bottom Line

The Wisconsin market supports a reasonable starting estimate of **\$65,000-\$75,000/year** for a newly graduated junior developer from an associate-level pathway, with many roles already landing comfortably above the **\$25/hour high-wage benchmark** used by SWTC.

The three Wisconsin breakdowns show the same basic pattern:

- By **city**, wages are strongest in Madison and Milwaukee but remain competitive across the state
- By **role**, software engineering and software developer tracks generally outperform web-only and lower-end QA entry points
- By **experience**, graduates can move from solid entry wages to substantially stronger compensation within one to two years

The added AI caveat makes the case stronger, not weaker:

- The near-term goal is no longer just to produce entry-level developers
- The stronger workforce goal is to produce **AI-augmented junior engineers** who can adapt to changing tools, workflows, and employer expectations
- That framing supports continued investment in current IT/AAISE programming and helps justify action tied to the **AI Program Velocity Briefing**